

Scripture Perspicuity

doc-scripture-perspicuity

Bibliology · Perspicuity · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Scripture is sufficiently clear in what it teaches concerning salvation that an ordinary believer reading with the Spirit's help can grasp those teachings without specialized mediation.

In plain language

Across Hebrew and Greek, the anchor verses make the text itself the actor reaching ordinary people, with no go-between in the grammar. In Deuteronomy 6:6 the commands rest on the addressee's own heart, and verse 7 has parents teaching children at home while sitting, walking, lying down, and rising. Psalm 119:105 calls the word a lamp to the reader's own foot. Psalm 119:130 is the sharpest: the opening of your words (a one-of-a-kind Hebrew word, *pethach*, which occurs only once in the entire Bible) gives light, and the grammar makes the words, not a teacher, the subject that gives understanding to the simple (*pethi*). Psalm 19:8 says the same thing with another verb: the testimony of Yahweh makes the simple wise. Second Timothy 3:15 says the sacred writings (*hieragmata*) were able to make Timothy wise for salvation from infancy through faith, not through a teaching office, and the grammar pins the ability on the writings themselves. On the saving core this is decisive, so the verdict is yes with high confidence. The reason careful readers still disagree is about scope, not the core, and it comes straight from the words. The very term for the simple (*pethi*) shows up mostly in Proverbs, where the simple are unstable people who must be coaxed to wisdom and can even perish in their folly, so the word says the text can reach them but does not promise they will grasp everything. The canon also gives a second pattern where helpers matter: in Nehemiah 8:8 the Levites read the law making it clear (*parash*) and giving the sense (*sekel*) so the people understood; in Acts 8 an official cannot follow one passage without a guide (*hodegeo*); and Second Peter 3:16 admits some things are hard to understand (*dysnoetos*, a word used only once, so its exact force cannot be cross-checked). The words affirm that what is needful for salvation reaches the simple directly, but they do not rank this against the helper pattern or say every passage is equally plain, and that gap is why the scope of clarity is debated.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0215	אור	or (verb)	to light	44
H0216	אור	or (noun)	light	120
H0995	בין	bin	to understand	170
H1121	בן	ben	son	
H1696	דבר	davar	to speak	
H1697	דבר	dabar	word	1,441

H3824	לבב	levav	heart	
H5216	נר	ner	lamp	60
H6567	פרשׁ	parash	to declare	
H6608	פתחׁ	pethach	opening	1
H6612	פתיׁ	pethi	simple	17
H6680	צוה	tsavah	to command	
H7919	שכלׁ	sakhal	be prudent	
H7922	שכלׁ	sekhel	understanding	
H8150	שנןׁ	shanan	to sharpen	9
G1025	βρέφος	brephos	infant	8
G1121	γράμμα	gramma	something written	14
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	209
G1417	δύο	duo	two	
G2413	ιερός	hieros	sacred	44
G4679	σοφίζω	sophizo	to make wise	2
G4991	σωτηρία	soteria	salvation	46

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Across the Torah (the first five books of the Bible), the Psalms, and a letter from Paul, the anchor clauses make the text itself the grammatical subject that reaches the ordinary recipient directly, with no go-between in the sentence structure. Deuteronomy 6:6-7 places the words on the addressee's own heart and assigns the verb to parents teaching children at home. Psalm 119:130 reads: the opening (pethach, a hapax meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) of your words gives light (or, in the Hebrew causative form 'to cause to do' called hiphil imperfect, meaning ongoing or repeated past action with the words as subject) and gives understanding (bin, also a hiphil participle) to the simple (pethi). Psalm 19:8 says the testimony of Yahweh makes the simple wise. Second Timothy 3:15 predicates of the sacred writings (hiera grammata) the present capacity (dynamena, a participle agreeing with the writings) to make wise (sophisai, an aorist infinitive meaning a completed past action in infinitive form) unto salvation through faith, not through a teaching office. The affirmative core is decided by the words themselves. The verdict is high confidence on the category, but the same vocabulary does not rank scope: it affirms that the text reaches the simple unto salvation without delimiting whether ALL content is equally clear, and the canon supplies a second pattern (Nehemiah 8:8 has Levites making it clear and giving the sense, Acts 8:31 has the official asking to be guided, 2 Peter 3:16 admits some things are hard to understand) in which mediation aids comprehension. Those two patterns are unranked by the words, which is why readers diverge on scope while agreeing on the saving core.

Scripture

Deut.6.6 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H1697 דָּבַר; H3824 לֵב, H6680 צֶהָ.

Reasoning. The commands (hadebarim, 'the words') are predicated as resting on the addressee's own heart (levavekha, second person singular, meaning 'your heart'). The ETCBC clause analysis (a database of Hebrew clause structure) tags the words as subject and predicate complement (a noun completing an 'X is Y' statement) of a stative clause (a clause describing a state rather than an action) with no priestly or scribal agent in the syntax. The recipient is the ordinary Israelite, not a cultic class (a class set apart for temple service).

Deut.6.7 · for · genre: law · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H8150 שָׁנַן, H1121 בֵּן, H1696 דָּבַר.

Reasoning. The verb 'teach diligently' (shanan) takes the parent as subject and the children (banekha, 'your sons') as recipients in ordinary domestic settings (sitting, walking, lying down, rising). The transmission line is household, not cultic (priestly or temple). Note the careful word study: of the 9 occurrences of 'teach diligently' (shanan) in the canon, this is the only one carrying the sense 'teach incisively' or 'repeat'. The other 8 mean 'sharpen' or 'pierce' (a sword, arrow, or tongue: Deuteronomy 32:41, Psalm 45:6, Psalm 64:4, Psalm 120:4, Psalm 140:4, Proverbs 25:18, Isaiah 5:28). The teach sense here is a single figurative extension of a 'sharpen' root, so the verb supports household transmission but is not itself a stable pedagogical term.

Ps.119.105 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H1697 דָּבַר; H5216 נֵר, H0216 אֹר.

Reasoning. The word (devarekha, 'your word') is predicated as 'lamp' (ner) to the speaker's own foot and 'light' (or) to his own path, a tight poetic word pair of two synonymous lines placing the reader in direct illuminated relation to the text. 'Lamp' (ner) occurs 60 times and is predominantly the literal sanctuary lamp; here it is used figuratively for the word, which the metaphor figure marks.

Ps.119.130 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H6608 פָּתַח; H0215 אֹר, H6612A פֶּתִי; H0995 בֵּין.

Reasoning. Morphology (the study of word forms) resolves the grammar decisively. 'Opening' or 'unfolding' (pethach, a true hapax, meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) is a construct noun (a noun bound to another in 'X of Y' form), the opening or unfolding of your words. The verb 'give light' (or) is hiphil imperfect (the Hebrew causative form 'to cause to do' in ongoing or repeated past action) third masculine singular: 'it gives light,' with the words as subject. 'Give understanding' (bin) is a hiphil participle (the Hebrew causative form as a verbal adjective), giving understanding to, and the recipient is the petayim, 'the simple.' The grammatical subject of both the illuminating and the understanding is the text itself, with no mediator in the clause. Psalm 19:8 supplies the same pattern with a different verb: the testimony of Yahweh 'makes wise' (chakam, hiphil) the simple.

2Tim.3.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2413 ἱερός, G1121 γράμμα, G1025 βρέφος, G4679 σοφίζω, G4991 σωτηρία

Reasoning. The word-form analysis confirms the predication. 'Sacred' (hieros) is A-APN (an adjective in the accusative plural neuter), qualifying 'writings' (grammata) N-APN (a noun in the accusative plural neuter), the only place in the canon where the otherwise temple word 'sacred' (hieros, 44 occurrences, dominantly the temple) modifies 'writings' to yield 'sacred writings,' that is, Scripture. 'Be able' (dynamai) is V-PNP-APN (a verb, present participle, accusative plural neuter), a present participle agreeing with the writings, which carry the capacity. 'Make wise' (sophizo) is V-AAN (a verb, aorist infinitive meaning a completed past action in infinitive form), 'to make wise.' The recipient is named apo brephous, 'from infancy,' the lower bound of cognitive capacity. The stated instrument is dia pisteos, 'through faith in Christ Jesus,' not a teaching office.

Neh.8.8 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6567 פִּירַשׁ, H7922 שָׁקַל, H0995 בִּין.

Reasoning. The clause sequence is: they read in the scroll, in the law of God, 'making it clear' or 'distinctly' (meforash, from parash), and 'giving the sense' (sekel), and they 'understood' (bin) the reading. Here the Levites are the explicit grammatical agents who make clear and give the sense so that the people understand. This is the canon's strongest counter pattern: a teaching class interposed between text and hearer to enable comprehension. The verbs of clarifying take human subjects, not the text.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Ps.119.105	Prov.6.23	openbible	198
Ps.119.105	Ps.43.3	openbible	171
Ps.119.105	Ps.18.28	openbible	151
Ps.119.105	2Pet.1.19	openbible	137
Ps.119.105	Ps.19.8	openbible	109
Ps.119.130	Ps.119.105	openbible	41
Ps.119.130	2Cor.4.6	openbible	31
Ps.119.130	Ps.19.7	openbible	25
Deut.6.7	Deut.11.19	openbible	34
Deut.6.7	Eph.6.4	openbible	29
Deut.6.6	Col.3.16	openbible	18
2Tim.3.15	2Tim.1.5	tsk	1
2Tim.3.15	Ps.19.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Neh.8.8 · addressed

The Levites are the grammatical agents who 'make the law clear' (parash) and 'give the sense' (sekel) so the people 'understand' (bin). This is a real counter pattern in which mediation enables comprehension, and the words make the human teachers the subjects, not the text. It does not overturn the affirmative anchors, where the text is the subject acting on the simple, but it shows the canon supplies a second, mediated pattern alongside the direct one. The vocabulary does not rank the two, which is the lexical source of divergence on scope.

Acts.8.30-31 · addressed

The official asks pos gar an dynaimen ean me tis hodegesi me, 'how can I unless someone guides me.' The verb 'guide' (hodegeo) occurs 5 times (Matthew 15:14, Luke 6:39, John 16:13 the Spirit guides into all truth, Acts 8:31, Revelation 7:17). Its sense is guidance toward understanding, here of one specific Isaianic servant text. The official then believes without further mediation. This complicates a maximalist 'no help' reading but is consistent with the affirmative pattern on saving content reaching the ordinary reader.

2Pet.3.16 · addressed

Peter notes some things in Paul's letters are 'hard to understand' (dysnoeta), which 'the untaught' (amatheis) distort. Both 'hard to understand' (dysnoetos) and 'untaught' (amathes) are hapax legomena (words that occur only once in the entire Bible), so their precise sense cannot be triangulated from canon usage and must be read from this one context. The lexical force is that DIFFICULTY exists for some texts, not OPACITY of saving content. The contrast term 'untaught' (amathes) presupposes that taught ordinary readers can grasp it. This qualifies scope without denying the saving core.

1Cor.2.14 · addressed

The natural person (psychikos anthropos) does not receive the things of the Spirit. This conditions reception on the Spirit's work, which the question stem already grants with 'the Spirit's help.' The complicating force lands on the unregenerate reader (the one not born again), not on the ordinary regenerate reader the proposition has in view.

Prov.1.22 · addressed

The anchor term 'the simple' (pethi) occurs 17 times in the canon and is concentrated in wisdom literature, with 15 of the MACULA (a Hebrew Bible interlinear database) occurrences in Proverbs. There the simple are the morally unstable who must be summoned and won to wisdom (Proverbs 1:22, Proverbs 8:5, Proverbs 9:4-6) and who can perish in their simplicity (Proverbs 1:32). So the same word that Psalm 119:130 and Psalm 19:8 say the text makes wise also names a class that needs active instruction. The word affirms the text can reach the simple but does not guarantee uptake or delimit which content, which underdetermines the scope the proposition asks about.

Concordance traversed

H1697, H6612A, H0995, H0215, H0216, H5216, H8150, H6608, H7922, H6567, H7919, G1121, G1025, G4679, G2413, G4991, G1410, G1417

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Anchor verses sit outside the published ECM apparatus scope (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, covering Deuteronomy, Psalms, 2 Timothy, Nehemiah). The 2 Timothy 3:15 reading 'sacred writings' (hiera grammata) is textually stable across the major witnesses in the MACULA-Greek SBLGNT and Nestle1904 editions, and no apparatus entry in scope would invert the predication. The hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'opening' (pethach) in Psalm 119:130 is the printed Masoretic consonantal text (the standard Hebrew Bible text without vowel points) with no competing reading in the queried Hebrew layer.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

grammatico-historical (direct-predication reading): affirms · In the anchor clauses the text is the grammatical subject acting on the ordinary recipient (heart, foot, path, infant, the simple) with no cultic or scribal agent in the syntax. Psalm 119:130 has the words as subject of both the hiphil (Hebrew causative form, 'to cause to do') 'it gives light' and the hiphil participle 'giving understanding,' and 2 Timothy 3:15 makes the sacred writings (hiera grammata) the bearer of the capacity to make wise unto salvation through faith. On the saving core the reading is decisive.

mediated-comprehension reading (scope-restricted): affirms in essentials, denies in full scope · This reading takes the proposition's saving core as granted but limits it. Nehemiah 8:8 makes human teachers the grammatical subjects who 'make clear' (parash) and 'give the sense' (sekel). Acts 8:31 has the official unable to understand a specific text without a guide ('to guide,' hodegeo). 2 Peter 3:16 says some things are 'hard to understand' (dysnoetos). Read together, these say the text reaches the simple on what is needful for salvation, but not that every passage is equally clear, and that ordinary means of teaching are part of how the simple come to understand. In its strongest form this is not a denial of the saving core but a denial that clarity extends to all content without help.

patristic-typological: affirms with nuance · Typological readings (readings that find foreshadowing patterns) layer additional senses on the plain sense but do not deny the plain sense's accessibility for salvation. The typological surplus is supplementary, not the gate, so it neither establishes nor removes the perspicuity (clarity) of the saving content.

The verdict turns on direct predication in the affirmative anchor clauses, so grammatico-historical (a method that reads the text by grammar and historical context) is primary. The divergence among readers is not over the saving core but over scope, and it is traceable to vocabulary that affirms a category (the text reaches the simple unto salvation) without ranking it against a second canon pattern (mediated clarifying in Nehemiah 8:8 and guiding in Acts 8:31).

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether the lexical pattern of Scripture predicates the accessibility of its saving content to ordinary readers without specialized mediation.

The English term 'perspicuity' (clarity) is a technical post-biblical loan from Latin *perspicuitas* and is most strongly associated with one tradition's confessional vocabulary, so the stem encodes a tradition's framing. The neutralized form restates the proposition in lexical terms (predication of accessibility) so the verdict tracks the text rather than the framing. The verdict was derived on the original stem and remains 'affirms true.' The deepened lexical work did not flip the verdict, it sharpened the rationale: VERDICT-CHANGED: NO. The affirmative saving core is grammatically foreclosed in the anchors, while the scope question is left open by the vocabulary, which is the honest place this doctrine lands.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.6
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.7
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.119.105
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.119.130
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Neh.8.8
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Tim.3.15
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Pet.3.16
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.119.130
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.6.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.15
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6612A
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6608
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8150
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4679
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1121
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Ps.119.105
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Ps.119.130
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Tim.3.15

License audit

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Reason. Citations include MACULA-Hebrew and MACULA-Greek, both CC-BY-NC-4.0, which forbids bulk redistribution. The decisive morphology (the hiphil subject in Psalm 119:130, the A-APN qualifier in 2 Timothy 3:15, and the agent verbs in Nehemiah 8:8) was read from these interlinear and morphology layers, so the safe flag is set false honestly rather than under citing to flip it.

Source	License	Redistribute
MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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Flags

(none)